

CELEBRATION ON WHEELS Guests celebrate inside a metro coach rented for a private party in Bhopal

plan has zoomed to Rs 12,800 crore. Officials ascribe this mostly to a GST hike from 12 to 18 per cent on materials. The routes also mutated, with the underground sections increasing. At grade, construction costs around Rs 100 crore per km; elevated makes it around Rs 300 crore per km; tunnelling ups that to Rs 800 per km.

Both projects are funded 60 per cent by foreign lenders: the Asian Development Bank and New Development Bank for Indore, the European Investment Bank for Bhopal. Of the remaining 40 per cent, half is picked up by the Centre, the remaining by the state government.

Krishna Chaitanya, MD, MPMRCL, reasons that reading it this way is flawed: "Even the Delhi Metro took 20 years to get the 40 lakh ridership it presently has. The Indore and Bhopal Metros are barely a year old and have very little coverage for them to attract ridership." He says unless at least 17-18 km of the projects become functional, connecting major workplaces in the cities and peripheral areas where working populations live, the ridership will remain low. The crux, according to planners, is that a critical part of the project needs to get going for the metro to get ridership.

Meanwhile, in both Bhopal and Indore, the local bus network has also considerably weakened. The fleets in both cities are depleted and new investment is not coming in. This has led to an increase in congestion. Thanks partly to a sudden increase in battery-operated rickshaws—filling the gap between demand and supply but proving to be a traffic nightmare in themselves.

The viability of the projects, officials say, was vetted at multiple levels. Passenger traffic projections were studied by six central departments before being approved—since Peak Hour Peak Direction Traffic should be at least 20,000 for a city to get a metro. "Ridership for Bhopal will stand at 4 lakh per day upon completion by 2035-36; for Indore, it will be 5 lakh, as per the DPR," says Chaitanya. "Success should be judged then." Just that it seems a rather long wait in unmoving traffic. ■

Takeaways

- **Metro ridership well short of expectations in both Bhopal and Indore**
- **Officials insist metro viability will depend on completing larger sections of the network**

▶ KERALA

A PORTABLE DEAL WITH THE ADANIS

A stake sale at Vizhinjam port, to a Swiss container major, sets off a debate. What will CM Satheesan do?

By **Jeemon Jacob**

THE NEW CONGRESS CHIEF MINISTER, V.D. Satheesan, had not yet exhausted that heady feeling of newfound political celebrityhood conferred on him earlier this summer. Nothing clouded the air except a late monsoon and some sharp repartee between him and the deposed Left. But that honeymoon period has run aground on the angry beaches of Vizhinjam in capital Thiruvananthapuram. This is where an ambitious but controversy-ridden project, India's first deep-water transshipment port, had started operations in 2024. It's seeing rollicking business—by this June, it had welcomed its thousandth commercial vessel, including some of the world's largest mother ships, inducing them to this strategic entrepot sitting just 10 nautical miles from major global shipping lines.

But what lashed ashore was an unseen undercurrent: news that industrialist Gautam Adani had inked a Rs 13,200-crore deal to offload 49 per cent stake in Adani Vizhinjam Port Private Limited (AVPPL)—the project-specific company formed to operate the port concession won by its other entity, the Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ)—to the Geneva-headquartered MSC, the world's largest container shipping company. And it had done so without informing the state. The Adani Group had formed AVPPL for financing, building and operating the Vizhin-